



To Sell is Human

The Surprising Truth About Persuading,
Convincing and Influencing Others

BY DANIEL H. PINK

The Big “So What”



When we think of “sales”, most of us think of pushy door-to-door salespeople or slimy used-car salesmen. In this book, Pink shows how outdated this perspective is. In fact, *all* of us sell – as part of our work and lives, we constantly influence, sway or persuade others to take action. Whether you are in a sales role, or need to influence others at work, **this book provides fresh perspectives and useful techniques to help you improve your ability to move and influence others.**

Redefining Sales



Most of us don’t consider ourselves to be salespeople. In fact, we tend to associate sales negatively with words like “slimy”, dishonest”, or “pushy”. In the book, **Pink shows us how outdated our notion of sales can be, how the world of selling has changed, and why everyone sells.** In fact, many companies that thrived on the traditional sales approach (e.g. the Fuller Brush Company, Encyclopedia Britannica) have already faded into oblivion.



The Shift from Selling to Moving



Monetary sales. In today’s digital internet age, consumers are able to do their own research and comparisons, and get purchase advice from their social networks. In most cases, consumers have as much (if not more) information as the salesperson – cajoling or withholding information can no longer work, and **the traditional way of selling is dead. To persuade people, you must move them.**



Non-monetary sales. Most people spend about 40% of their workhours doing “non-sales selling”, i.e. convincing others to

KEY QUOTES

“The ability to move others to exchange what they have for what we have is crucial to our survival and our happiness.”

“We’re persuading convincing, and influencing others to give up something they’ve got in exchange for what we’ve got.”

“Like it or not, we’re all in sales now.”

“To sell well is to convince someone else to part with resources – not to deprive that person, but to leave them better off in the end.”

“In a world where anybody can find anything with just a few keystrokes, intermediaries like salespeople are superfluous.”

“As we rely ever more on websites and smartphones to locate and purchase what we need, salespeople themselves – not to mention the very act of selling – will be swept into history’s dustbin.”

exchange their resources (e.g. expertise, time, effort, attention) for something they want. **Such activities are a significant part of work, and are vital for one's professional success.**



Everyone sells. When we consider both sales and non-sales selling, *everyone sells*. However, **instead of product pushing, we must now move people into action.** In Pink's words, we're all in the "moving business".



The 3Es Behind the Moving Business

How did so many of us end up as salespeople, or rather, movers? The book explains 3 key factors (or 3Es) behind this trend:



Entrepreneurship: The Web and smartphones have made it easier and more affordable to start a business, bringing a surge in the number of small and micro businesses (small businesses operated by 1-2 people). While large organizations rely on specialization, small business owners must wear multiple hats; they must oversee all aspects of their business, including sales. **As the number of entrepreneurs continue to grow, so will the number of salespeople.**



Elasticity: In steady, unchanging environments, specialized skills can be highly effective. However, **in today's ever-changing landscape, we must learn and adapt quickly - "elasticity" is now an essential skill for success.** This involves:

- Doing jobs and applying skills that go beyond artificial boundaries like marketing, design, or accounting; and
- Developing skills that can be repurposed or applied in new ways to match industry changes.

Whether you are an employee or a business owner, your work will become increasingly elastic. For example:

- Atlassian, an enterprise software developer, achieved \$100 million in annual sales without a single "salesperson". Instead, everyone in the company - from the engineer to the customer service staff - focuses on sales.
- Palantir, which specializes in big data analytics and software,

KEY QUOTES

"The very technologies that were supposed to obliterate salespeople have lowered the barriers to entry for small entrepreneurs and turned more of us into sellers."

"Being an entrepreneur, for at least part of one's livelihood, could become the norm rather than the exception. And a world of entrepreneurs is a world of salespeople."

"A world of flat organizations and tumultuous business conditions...punishes fixed skills and prizes elastic ones."

"What an individual does day to day on the job now must stretch across functional boundaries... And when the next technologies emerge and current business models collapse, those skills will need to stretch again in different directions."

uses “forward-deployed engineers” to interact with customers. That way, the engineers can directly address customers’ problems, learn what customers need, find problems and figure out what sells. Palantir doesn’t even provide sales training; instead, all its staff read 2 books that emphasize the importance of understanding market information, and nimbleness in thinking.

The skill of moving others is an example of an elastic skill that’s relevant across time, functions, and industries.



“Ed-Med”: Education and Healthcare are 2 of the fastest-growing industries, and Pink refers to them as “Ed-Med”. Motivating students to pay attention and learn, and encouraging patients to adopt healthier lifestyles, are all aspects of non-sales selling. **At the core, Ed-Med is about moving people to take action, so they can achieve an outcome that’s good for them. The only way to convince people to change their behaviour is to engage them as partners or participants.** Only then can you find a way to match what they want with what you can offer. As the Ed-Med industry grows, more people need to become well-versed in the art of moving others.



From Caveat Emptor to Caveat Venditor

In the past, sellers had more information than buyers, and the onus was on buyers to check the quality and suitability of the products, before making a purchase (**Caveat Emptor**). People had no recourse even if they were cajoled into bad deals.

However, **with the internet, the power has shifted in buyers’ favour.**

- Buyers today have almost **equal access to information** as sellers. For example, if you wish to buy a pre-owned car, you can do your online research on various car models, used-car companies, and even a vehicle’s accident and repair history.
- Buyers also have the **option to retaliate** (e.g. share bad reviews on the internet or social media) if they’re unfairly treated.

The new rule is now **Caveat Venditor** (i.e. seller-beware, with the seller being accountable for providing the necessary info to the buyer). **Effective selling is no longer about being the most persistent**

KEY QUOTES

“Most of us are movers; some of us are super-movers.”

“To move people fully and deeply requires something more – not looking at the student or the patient as a pawn on a chessboard but as a full participant in the game.”

“In a world of information parity, the new guiding principle is caveat venditor – seller beware.”

“When buyers can know more than sellers, sellers are no longer protectors and purveyors of information. They’re the curators and clarifiers of it – helping to make sense of the blizzard of facts, data and options.”

“In a world of information parity, the new guiding principle is caveat venditor – seller beware.”

“Whether you’re in traditional sales or non-sales selling, the low road is now harder to pass and the high road – honesty, directness, and transparency – has become the better, more pragmatic, long-term route.”

or aggressive. It's about being transparent and empathetic, and helping buyers to make sense of available facts and options, so they can make the best choices.

To achieve this, it's important to bust 3 myths about sales:

- **Selling is not a role for less intelligent people.** In fact, the skills needed for sales are as valuable, if not more so, than high-IQ roles like engineering or medicine.
- **Salespeople are not money-grabbers.** Outstanding salespeople are often driven by a wider purpose, and non-sales selling is primarily motivated by non-monetary factors.
- **There are no "natural salespeople".** Everyone sells, and we all sell naturally.

How to Be a Good Mover



Many successful salespeople live by this age-old adage, "Always be Closing". They're singularly focused on getting their prospects to say "yes" to what they're selling. **Pink proposes a new set of ABCs – Attunement, Buoyancy and Clarity – that are better suited for the new paradigm.**



Attunement

Attunement is about aligning yourself with others and the situation, stepping outside your own perspective and putting yourself in others' shoes. To effectively attune yourself to others' perspectives, there are 3 key rules or principles:



- **Lessen your power to amplify it.** Research has shown that people with more power are usually less sensitized to others' points of view. **Hence, regardless of your actual position, assume that you are starting with a position of lesser power.** This helps you to attune yourself to others' perspectives and become a more effective mover.

Amazon founder, Jeff Bezos, always adds an empty chair in his meetings, to remind everyone to consider the perspective

KEY QUOTES

"Each of us – because we're human – has a selling instinct, which means that anyone can master the basics of moving others."

"Attunement, buoyancy, and clarity: These three qualities... are the new requirements for effectively moving people on the remade landscape of the twenty-first century."

"Attunement is the ability to bring one's actions and outlook into harmony with other people and with the context you're in."

"The ability to move people now depends on power's inverse: understanding another person's perspective, getting inside his head, and seeing the world through his eyes."

of an important stakeholder - the customer. Try this at your meetings.



Use your head + heart. To be effectively attuned, you need both cognitive thinking and empathy (i.e. logic *and* feelings). In fact, you should consider not just the people themselves, but also their wider social networks and relationships (which affect their biases, preferences etc.). Try these 2 exercises to hone your attunement:

- o Meet the time traveller. Try to explain a modern item (e.g. a smartphone) to an imaginary person from 300 years ago – it'll force you to consider how different others' perspectives are.
- o Draw a discussion. To tune in to others' behaviours and moods, map out the flow of content and feelings at a meeting.



Strategic mimicry. We naturally (and often sub-consciously) mirror the behaviours of the people we interact with. Strategic mimicry (e.g. repeating others' words, aping their mannerisms) can produce better results in negotiations or sales. However, it has to be sincere and natural, like a chameleon blending into its environment.

- o Try the Watch-Wait-Wane approach. *Watch* the other person, then *wait* a while before copying something (e.g. words, tone, gesture). Slowly *wane* to become less conscious of your mimicry.
- o Mirror image. Pair up with a partner. Study each other for 30s, then turn around and change a part of your appearance. Face each other again after 60s and try to identify the change(s).

Many people assume that good sales people should be extraverts. However, research suggests that **ambiverts – people who are neither extremely introverted nor extroverted – fare even better at moving others.** That's because they can balance between listening (and keeping quiet) and speaking up. Identify your natural tendencies at www.danpink.com/assessment, and learn to adjust your behaviours - introverts should learn to speak up more, while extroverts should learn to hold back and listen.

KEY QUOTES

"Synching our mannerisms and vocal patterns to someone else so that we both understand and can be understood is fundamental to attunement."

"The key is to be strategic and human – to be strategic by being human."

"Most of us are ambiverts, sitting near the middle, not the edges, happily attuned to those around us. In some sense, we are born to sell."



Buoyancy

One of the toughest aspects of sales is the sheer volume of rejections. **Buoyancy is about balancing determination with optimism.** Use these 3 tips *before, during, and after* the sales process, to cope with rejections:



Questioning Self-Talk. Use this to prepare yourself *before* the sale. Pink suggests that this is even more effective than affirmations or positive self-talk. Instead of affirmations like “I can do this” or “I will achieve this”, **ask yourself, “Can I do this?” or “Can I achieve this?”**. Then, list down 5 reasons why the answer should be “yes”. Such questions draw out your intrinsic motivations, as well as strategies and answers needed to complete the task.



Positivity Ratio. *During* the sales process, negative emotions, like fear or anger, can trigger the fight-or-flight response in others. Positivity, on the other hand, brings several benefits:

- It puts people in an expansive mode, so they focus on possibilities and are more open to ideas for a mutually-beneficial outcome;
- It's more effective in transferring belief or conviction; and
- It paves the way for a long-term relationship or future dealings.

However, some negative experience is still good to keep us on our toes and motivate growth. **Research suggests that a positivity-negativity ratio of about 3:1 is most ideal** – having 3 positive encounters (e.g. a praise, a happy customer) for every negative encounter (e.g. a rejection, an embarrassing incident) helps you to flourish.

- Aim to achieve the 3:1 ratio. Identify and monitor your ratio **via this website/link**. Focus on displaying positive emotions throughout the day; it'll also boost your chances to move others.
- Count the number of rejections you've had in a day or week, and frame up some of them. Embrace the rejections and remind yourself how much you've already survived.

KEY QUOTES

“Positive self-talk is generally more effective than negative self-talk. But the most effective self-talk of all doesn't merely shift emotions. It shifts linguistic categories. It moves from making statements to asking questions.”

“While negative emotions help us see trees, positive ones reveal forests.”

“Actually believing in what you're selling has become essential on sales' new terrain.”

“A particular recipe – a golden ratio of positivity – leads to the best results.”

“Optimism, it turns out, isn't a hollow sentiment. It's a catalyst that can stir persistence, steady us during challenges, and stoke the confidence that we can influence our surroundings.”



Explanatory Style. How we explain our experiences *after* the sales process can determine if we feel helpless or resilient. Renowned psychologist, Martin Seligman, found that people who explain negative experiences as permanent, pervasive and personal, tend to develop “learned helplessness”.

- Learn to adjust your explanatory style. Think of a rejection as temporary (it’ll pass), specific (it’s unique to this incident) and external (it’s not about me), so you can cope and perform better.
- Write yourself a rejection letter. Use this to get over the fear of rejection, and possibly identify blind spots in your proposal.



Clarity

We’ve no shortage of information today. **The ability to cut through the clutter, identify problems, and present solutions clearly, has become more valuable.**



Identify problems. With the internet, finding information is easy. What’s more challenging is **helping people to find or identify problems that they didn’t previously see** – these new perspectives move people and influence their choices.

To identify the right problems, we need to get skilled in 2 areas:

- **Curating information.** Rather than present more data, learn to sort through the sea of information, and present the most relevant and illuminating pieces. Try this approach: Seek (define the topic and collect the best possible data), sense (make sense of the info), and share them (through social media, email, etc.)
- **Asking questions:** Rather than present answers, learn to ask good questions that help to uncover underlying issues. For example:
 - o Use these 2-questions: “On a scale of 1 to 10, how ready are you to...(do the desired action)?” Then ask, “Why isn’t your number *lower*?” When you ask for a lower (rather than higher) score, it makes people examine their existing motivation for action.

KEY QUOTES

“Clarity (is) the capacity to help others see their situations in fresh and more revealing ways and to identify problems they didn’t realize they had.”

“The ability to move others hinges less on problem solving than on problem finding.”

“One of the most effective ways of moving others is to uncover challenges they may not know they have.”

- o Try the “Five Whys” approach: Identify an issue, and find the underlying problems by asking “Why” 5 times.



Frame your Offer. Try using one or more of these 5 frames to highlight the value of your solution:

- Reduce. When you give people *fewer options* to choose from, sales can actually increase. Removing inexpensive items from a bundle can also increase the *perceived value* of the bundle. Remember: less can be more.
- Experience. Experiences generally bring greater customer satisfaction and repeat business (vs mere products). Sell experiences, not products (e.g. sell indulgence, not chocolates).
- Labels. When people are labelled positively (e.g. “generous”, “kind”), they tend to raise their behaviour to fit the labels.
- Blemishes. If your offer won’t be scrutinized in detail, try adding a small blemish to the list of positives. This highlights your positives by contrast, and adds a touch of honesty.
- Potential. Research shows that people are actually more receptive to things that have great potential (“this could be the next game-changer”), than things that’re already good (“this has totally changed the game”). Don’t just emphasize your past achievements; highlight what you can achieve in the future.



Give clear directions. Once people see the problems and the value of your solutions, make sure you provide details on what exactly they should do next.

What To Do to Move People



Now that we know the qualities required to effectively move people, let’s look at the **3 things we need to do – Pitch, Improvise and Serve.**

KEY QUOTES

“Being honest about the existence of a small blemish can enhance your offering’s true beauty.”

“Today, we have more opportunities to get out our message...But our recipients have far more distractions.”



Pitch

A pitch is not mean to convince others; it merely arouses interest and draws others into a conversation. For many years, salespeople practiced “elevator pitches” – a succinct way of presenting what you offer, in the short time you have with a stranger in a lift. Well, this is outdated, says Pink. Today, everyone is constantly on their mobile phones, and we should learn 6 new tricks to replace the elevator pitch:

1 One-word Pitch. The idea (conceptualized by advertising veteran Maurice Saatchi) is to distill what people associate with you to just one word. For example, Google has claimed the word “search”, MasterCard has claimed the word “priceless”, and President Obama built his strategy around the word “forward”. Start with a 50-word pitch, reduce it to 20 words, 6 words, and eventually 1 word.

? Question Pitch. When you make a statement, it’s received passively. When you ask a question, people respond aloud or in their heads, and they consider why they agree or disagree with you. Find your strongest arguments and frame them into questions.

🎵 Rhyming Pitch. Use sentences that rhyme (e.g. “Leaders are readers” or “Life is mostly strife”). These are more easily processed and remembered, and people tend to unconsciously believe them to be true or accurate.

✉️ The subject-line pitch. Every email that we send is actually a pitch – the title determines if someone will read it. Generally, people open emails when:

- It contains something obviously *useful* to them, i.e. they have something to gain or lose (e.g. “5 proven ways to double your income”); or
- It’s uncertain what the email contains, i.e. it piques their *curiosity* (e.g. “5 strange ways to make money”).

The former is more effective if the recipient has a high email load.

KEY QUOTES

“The purpose of a pitch...is to offer something so compelling that it begins a conversation, rings the other person in as a participant, and eventually arrives at an outcome that appeals to both of you.”

“In a world where buyers have ample information and an array of choices, the pitch is often the first word, but it’s rarely the last.”

“By making people work just a little harder, question pitches prompt people to come up with their own reasons for agreeing (or not).”

“Remember: Pitches that rhyme are more sublime.”



Twitter pitch. A tweet has 140 characters or less, and should get the reader to reply, click a link, or share with others. Better-performing tweets tend to ask questions, provide useful info and/or links to the latest news. Try developing your pitch in 120 characters or less.



Pixar pitch. Pixar films usually follow a 6-part narrative structure: “Once upon a time, Every day, One day, Because of that, Because of that, Until finally,”. Try applying this structure to your pitch.

Practice sheets for the above are available from [Pink’s website](#). In the book, Pink also provides a range of other tips, such as considering what you want someone to know, feel, and do after hearing your pitch, using visuals or props, and learning from others’ pitches.



Improvise

Things don’t always go according to plan and we need to improvise. Here are 3 useful tips for improvisation:



Listen out for offers. Often, what we perceive to be a rejection is actually an offer. For instance, “I’m not ready to buy that yet” could be an offer to buy later, or “\$100 is out of my budget” could be an invitation for a lower quote. During your conversations, try *pausing for 5 seconds* before you respond, so you learn to slow down and listen.



Use “Yes and...”. Instead of saying “No” or “Yes, but...”, use “Yes, and...” to shift your mind toward possibilities. For example, “Yes, I understand your concerns, and....”



Make others look good. Rather than focus on sharing your views, ask questions and be genuinely interested to find out why others see or feel differently from you. Try this exercise: Find a partner, select a topic with 2 distinctly different views, and have each person adopt a stance. Get your partner to make his/her case – you can only listen and reply with open-ended questions that do not convey an opposite or contradicting view.

KEY QUOTES

“The best pitches are short, sweet and easy to retweet.”

“The only way to hear (offers) is to change the way you listen and then change the way you respond.”

“Many of us have become desensitized to ‘win-win’ from hearing it so regularly but experiencing it so rarely.”



Serve

When people are genuinely moved, the impact can be long-lasting. Here are 2 principles to make selling more meaningful:



Be Personal. When you put a face to an issue or situation, it makes it personal and tangible. A medical report (full of test results and diagnosis) can feel cold and distant. However, when you add the patient's photograph to the report, it creates a strong reminder that there's a real person whose life or health is at stake.

There are 2 sides to making something personal. First, you need to think of the *people you serve* as unique individuals (e.g. put yourself in their shoes, or treat everyone like how you'd treat your grandmother). Second, you want them to *know who you* are, as the person behind the product or service (e.g. include your photograph when inviting feedback).



Focus on purpose. Research found that people are more willing to take action for a bigger purpose, than for their personal gains. For example, hospital professionals were more willing to wash their hands when they were reminded of the effect on their patients' health (than when they were reminded of the effect on their own health). Sales and participation increased when people heard stories of how their contributions would improve others' lives. Hence, remind people of the reason for participating, and appeal to their sense of purpose or empathy.

- o Rather than try to sell more to people, try to deliver beyond expectations. In other words, upserve, don't upsell.
- o Do a self-check. Always ask yourself: (a) If the person agrees to buy what I'm selling, will his/ her life improve? (b) Will the world be a better place after I finish this interaction? If your answer isn't "yes" to both questions, review what you're doing.

KEY QUOTES

"In both traditional sales and non-sales selling, we do better when we move beyond solving a puzzle to serving a person."

"The stories made the work personal; their contents made it purposeful. This is what it means to serve: improving another's life and, in turn improving the world."

"Don't try to increase what they can do for you. Elevate what you can do for them."